Thriftly — Refined App Plan (v2)

Secondhand fashion in Zimbabwe: collect, inspect, or get it delivered. Built for English, Shona and Ndebele from day one.

What changed from v1: (1) language is now a core product pillar, not a localisation afterthought; (2) the MVP is cut down so it can actually be validated; (3) contradictions in the old plan are resolved; (4) open questions now carry a recommended default; (5) metrics have targets and Phase 0 has go/no-go gates.

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1. Positioning

One-liner: Find secondhand clothes near you, reserve them, and check them in person at the stand, or have them brought to you where delivery works.

Core insight: In Zimbabwe, thrifting is a trust-and-touch purchase. Buyers want to feel the fabric, check the size and spot flaws. Delivery is expensive and unreliable. So **pickup and reserve-to-view are the product**; delivery is a pilot add-on.

Tone: fast, playful, local, not preachy. Copy must sound like people actually speak, including the natural mixing of English, Shona and Ndebele.

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2. Problem (tightened)

- Thrift shopping is discovery-by-luck: you must go, dig and hope.
- Online resale means shipping delays, and photos cannot answer size, stretch, fabric or smell.
- Stores and bhero stands have great stock but little online presence, no formal addresses and often no smartphone.
- Delivery is costly (fuel, distance, thin courier supply, landmark addresses).
- Vendors lose a market day when buyers no-show or when holds are unreliable.
- Most digital products assume English literacy, cheap data and a card. Many target users and almost all stand vendors do not fit that.

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3. Language & Localisation Strategy (new, core pillar)

3.1 Principles

1. **Three languages at launch for all core flows:** English (EN), chiShona (SN) and isiNdebele (ND). Core flows = onboarding, browse, item detail, reserve/pickup, order status, notifications, vendor tools.
2. **Language is chosen by the person, per person.** Ask on first launch (before anything else), with each language shown in its own name: *English · chiShona · isiNdebele*. Remember it and allow change in Profile at any time.
3. **Buyer and vendor languages are independent.** A Shona-speaking buyer reserving from an Ndebele-speaking vendor sees the app in Shona; the vendor sees the same reservation in Ndebele. System messages are translated per recipient; free text typed by a person is shown as written.
4. **Every channel is localised, not just the app:** push, SMS, WhatsApp bot, USSD menus, receipts, pickup instructions, error messages and help.
5. **Design for code-switching.** People mix languages ("ndiri kuda ku-reserve iyi"). Search and bot commands must accept mixed input.
6. **Extensible to other Zimbabwean languages** (e.g. Tonga, Kalanga, Venda, Nambya) by building the i18n layer properly once. Launch with the three above only.

3.2 Which language where (launch hypothesis)

- **Harare / Mbare / Mupedzanhamo cluster:** default Shona, strong English use.
- **Bulawayo and Matabeleland:** default Ndebele, strong English use.
- Default language on first open is suggested from device language and location, but never forced. The launch city choice (open question) decides which language gets the deepest QA first; the other still ships at v1.

3.3 Technical requirements

- **All UI strings externalised** in language files (EN / SN / ND). No hard-coded text, including images that contain text.
- **No string concatenation for sentences.** Shona and Ndebele use noun classes, concords and verb prefixes, so word-order tricks like "{count} + item" break. Use full-sentence templates with ICU-style message format and per-language plural/variant rules, e.g. one complete sentence for "1 item left" and another for "{n} items left".

- **Text expansion:** Shona and Ndebele strings are often 20–40% longer than English. Buttons, tabs and cards must wrap or truncate gracefully. Test every screen in all three languages.
- **Fonts and characters:** both languages use the Latin alphabet. Use fonts that render all letters and digraphs cleanly on low-end Android. Keep SMS/USSD copy GSM-7 safe (avoid curly quotes and special symbols) to stay within 160 characters per segment and avoid cost blow-ups.
- **Numbers, dates, money:** use Arabic numerals everywhere. Show currency explicitly (USD and ZiG; confirm current pricing and legal-tender rules before launch). Dates in DD/MM/YYYY with day and month names localised.
- **Fixed vocabulary is translated; vendor free text is not.** Condition grades, sizes, categories, colours, fulfilment modes, order statuses and fabric terms come from a controlled list with SN and ND labels. Titles and descriptions typed by vendors are stored in their original language with a language tag.
- **Language-aware search:** maintain a synonym map so "mbatya", "impahla", "clothes", "bhero", "mabhero", "mupedzanhamo" and misspellings all resolve to the right categories. Learn from search logs over time.
- **Language preference stored on User and Vendor** and attached to every outbound message.
- **Right-to-left / other scripts:** not required.

3.4 Translation process (quality matters more than speed)

- Use **native-speaker translators and reviewers** for Shona and Ndebele. Machine translation is acceptable only as a first draft, never shipped unreviewed.
- Maintain a **glossary and style guide** (see 3.6) so terms like *reserve*, *hold*, *pickup code*, *stand* are consistent across app, WhatsApp, SMS and USSD.
- Decide register: friendly everyday language, not stiff formal or heavily dialectal. Test with Harare and Bulawayo users, plus at least one rural-origin reviewer, since Shona dialects (Zezuru, Karanga, Manyika, Ndau, Korekore) differ.
- Maintain a **pseudo-localisation** and **string-length test** in CI so untranslated or overflowing strings are caught early.
- Add an in-app **"Report a wording problem"** link so users can correct translations.
- Budget for ongoing translation, not one-off.

3.5 Accessibility for low literacy

- Icon-led UI for key actions (reserve, pickup, sold, call, WhatsApp).
- **Voice notes** where possible: vendors can record an item description instead of typing; the bot and agents can read key steps aloud.
- Short sentences, large tap targets, minimal required typing.
- Confirmations use words **and** symbols (e.g. a tick and the localised word for "confirmed").
- WhatsApp and USSD use **numbered menus** so no typing is needed.

3.6 Starter glossary (DRAFT: must be reviewed by native speakers before use)

English	chiShona (draft)	isiNdebele (draft)
Hello	Mhoro / Mhoroi	Sawubona / Salibonani
Clothes	Mbatya	Izigqoko / Impahla
Buy	Tenga	Thenga
Sell	Tengesa	Thengisa
Price	Mutengo	Intengo
Reserve / hold for me	Ndichengetere	Ngibekele
Collect / pick up	Tora	Ukuthatha / Thatha
I'm here	Ndasvika	Ngifikile
Size	Saizi	Usayizi
Sold	Chatengeswa	Kuthengisiwe
Available	Chiripo	Kuyatholakala
Market stand	Stendi / Bhero	Isitendi / Ibhero
Confirmed	Zvatsimbiswa	Kuqinisekisiwe
Thank you	Ndatenda / Maita basa	Ngiyabonga / Siyabonga

These are working drafts to seed the glossary, not final copy. Final wording, spelling and register must come from vetted native-speaking translators.

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4. Target Users

Primary: urban buyers aged 18–35 who already thrift, comfortable on WhatsApp, on low-to-mid Android, data-conscious. Language preference varies and many are bilingual.

Secondary (supply): small thrift shops; bhero market and stand vendors (often feature-phone or basic-smartphone users, strong preference for Shona or Ndebele); casual sellers.

Tertiary: couriers/runners; Thriftly agents who onboard and photograph stock. **Agents must be fluent in the vendor's language** (Shona, Ndebele or both) and trained to demo the product in that language.

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5. Product Principles

1. Pickup and reserve-to-view first; delivery only where it works.
2. Works on 3G and low-end Android; WhatsApp/SMS are first-class channels.
3. Landmarks and pins, not street addresses.
4. Mobile money and cash before cards.
5. Every message, in every channel, in the user's language.
6. One item = one unit; holds prevent double-selling.
7. Never require a vendor to own a smartphone.

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6. Core Concepts

Item (single unit) · Vendor (shop, individual, stand, market-day vendor) · Feed (proximity-ranked) · Fulfilment mode (delivery / pickup / reserve-to-view, set per item) · Hold (cart, pickup or visit; auto-expires) · Visit reservation · Pickup code · Landmark location · Vendor-assisted listing · Batch (v1.5) · **Language preference (new, per user and per vendor)**

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7. Feature Areas (refined)

7.1 Onboarding & Auth

- **Language selection first**, then phone + OTP (primary), with Google/Apple optional.

- OTP via SMS in the chosen language, with a WhatsApp OTP fallback.
- Location permission with a short rationale in the user's language.
- Address as landmark note plus optional WhatsApp pin.
- Size and style prefs; default fulfilment mode.

7.2 Discovery

- Search, category/vibe filters, fulfilment filter, "Near you", "Reserve to view this week", "Picked for you".
- Delivery rail shown **only** in live delivery zones.
- Bottom nav: Home, Search, Orders, Profile.
- Language switcher reachable from the Home header and Profile.

7.3 Search & Filters

- Filters: size, brand, price, condition, distance, fulfilment mode, "has measurements", "open today", "at the stand today".
- Sort: distance, newest, price, soonest visit slot (ETA only where delivery is live).
- Multilingual and code-switched queries supported (see 3.3).

7.4 Item Detail

- Photo carousel, title, brand, size, condition grade, price, measurements, flaws.
- Fulfilment options with details (pickup readiness, next visit slots, delivery ETA where live).
- Vendor location: pin + landmark + market/stand name + days present, shown in the buyer's language where system-generated.
- Availability/scarcity, Save, Reserve, Contact vendor on WhatsApp (pre-filled message in the buyer's language).
- "Just sold" state with similar nearby items.

7.5 Cart & Checkout (MVP: single-vendor)

- Per-vendor fulfilment choice, hold timers clearly shown.
- Payment: EcoCash, OneMoney, InnBucks, ZIPIT via Paynow; cash on pickup where the vendor allows.
- Optional refundable deposit to secure a visit (vendor-toggleable).

- Pickup code issued on confirmation, delivered by app **and** SMS/WhatsApp.

7.6 Pickup, Visits & Tracking

- Pickup: code, directions (pin + landmark), "I'm here", vendor verifies code.
- Visit: slot reminder, "on my way", check-in, inspect, buy in person or in-app, vendor marks sold.
- Reminders sent in the buyer's language at fixed offsets (e.g. 24 h, 2 h before).
- Hold countdown visible; auto-release on expiry.

7.7 Orders & Refunds

- Active/Past, receipts, rebook visit, refund states. Refunds return to the original mobile-money wallet.

7.8 Seller Side (shop/stand/individual)

- Today's stats, incoming orders and visit requests, accept/decline, inventory, mark ready, mark sold, payouts.
- **Vendor web dashboard and WhatsApp bot available in EN / SN / ND.**
- Vendor can set a "not at the stand today" toggle by one tap or one WhatsApp keyword.

7.9 WhatsApp Bot & USSD (vendor, localised)

- Language menu on first contact ("1 English · 2 chiShona · 3 isiNdebele").
- Numbered menus for: new requests, accept, decline, mark ready, mark sold, today's visits, toggle availability.
- Free-text keywords accepted in all three languages and common spellings (e.g. accept: *accept / ndatambira / ngiyavuma*, to be finalised with translators).
- Voice-note input for listing descriptions (post-MVP transcription is a stretch goal).
- Graceful fallback: if the bot does not understand, offer the menu and offer an agent call-back.

7.10 Informal Vendors & Stands

- Vendor types, GPS pin + landmark + market + stand number + days present.
- Hours: fixed / market days / call first.

- **Vendor-assisted onboarding by language-matched agents**: verify phone/ID, photograph 10–30 items, record preferred language, create listings.
- Item cards clearly show "stand · no fixed address" with landmark and pin.
- Trust: phone verification, in-person onboarding, payout holds for new vendors.

7.11 Courier Side (pilot only)

- Batches, accept/decline, route, pickup/dropoff confirmation with photo, "can't find it" escalation, earnings.
- Courier prompts and customer-contact scripts in the courier's and customer's languages.

7.12 Payments (Zimbabwe)

- Mobile money first via Paynow; cards secondary; cash where offered.
- Prices shown in the vendor's chosen currency(ies); clear conversion/rounding rules if both USD and ZiG are supported.
- Refunds and payouts to mobile-money wallets.

7.13 Support & Help (new)

- Help centre articles and FAQ in EN/SN/ND, short and visual.
- Support via WhatsApp with agents who speak all three languages (or routing by language).
- Dispute flow for "not as described" in plain language.

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8. Key Flows (updated for language)

A. First open: pick language → phone OTP → location → sizes → home feed.

B. Reserve to view: browse → item → reserve → slot → optional deposit → vendor confirms (app or WhatsApp, in the vendor's language) → buyer gets reminder + landmark directions in the buyer's language → arrives, inspects → buys in person or in-app → vendor marks sold.

C. Pickup order: cart → pickup → window → pay → code → "I'm here" → vendor verifies → complete → rate.

D. Stand vendor onboarding: agent (matching language) visits → verifies → photographs stock → records language and hours → listings live → vendor gets WhatsApp bot in their language.

E. Hold expires / no-show: one missed slot → item releases → both sides notified in their own languages.

F. Item sells mid-browse: "just sold" → similar items nearby.

G. Delivery (pilot): cart → delivery → tracking → delivered → rate.

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9. Data Model Changes

Add to v1 model:

- **User:** `preferred_language` (en | sn | nd), `secondary_languages[]`, `preferred_channel` (app | whatsapp | sms), `currency_pref`.
- **Vendor:** `preferred_language`, `spoken_languages[]`, `channel` (app | whatsapp | ussd | agent_relayed), `currencies_accepted[]`.
- **Item:** `title`, `description`, each with `lang` tag; controlled-vocab fields stored as codes (not text) so they can be rendered in any language; optional `title_alt` translations.
- **Message template:** `key`, `lang`, `channel`, `text`, `version`, `status` (draft | reviewed | live).
- **Agent:** `languages[]`, `markets[]`.
- **Search synonym:** `term`, `lang`, `maps_to_category_or_tag`.
- **Hold:** reminder schedule and language stamped at creation.

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10. Non-Functional Requirements

- Real-time status updates with graceful polling fallback on poor networks.
- Push + WhatsApp/SMS fallback, **localised per recipient**.
- Inventory consistency: one item, one active hold. Defaults: cart hold 10 min; pickup hold 24 h; visit hold = slot length plus 15 min grace.
- Low-bandwidth mode: compressed images, lazy loading, 3G-friendly, small APK.
- Offline tolerance: queue actions and sync.

- Localisation QA: all three languages tested on every release; string-length and missing-translation checks in CI.
- Privacy and compliance: personal data and phone numbers handled per Zimbabwe's data-protection law; ID copies for vendors stored securely with limited access. *(Confirm current obligations with a Zimbabwean lawyer.)*
- Accessibility: readable contrast, scalable text, icon + text pairing.

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11. Monetisation

- Service fee on prepaid orders; delivery fee and priority upsell (delivery only).
- Seller commission, lower than shipping-based platforms.
- Vendor subscription for extra listings/visibility.
- Cash-pickup commission via weekly invoice or by netting against prepaid sales (recommended: net it, to avoid chasing cash).
- Promoted stand placement (later). Courier subscription (explore).

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12. MVP Scope (v1, tightened)

In:

- Language selection and full EN/SN/ND coverage of core flows, notifications, WhatsApp bot and help
- Phone OTP auth, landmark address, size prefs
- Home feed, search (multilingual synonyms), filters, item detail, save
- **Pickup orders with code** and **reserve-to-view with slots, holds and reminders**
- Single-vendor cart and checkout; mobile money + cash
- Orders history; refunds for failed pickups and no-shows
- Vendor: web dashboard + WhatsApp bot (accept/decline, mark ready, mark sold, visits, availability toggle)
- Language-matched agent-assisted onboarding for stands
- Basic buyer rating for no-show tracking

Pilot (not a general v1 promise): delivery in one dense zone, run semi-manually with a few couriers.

Out for v1: multi-store batching, city-wide delivery, public reviews, promoted listings, in-app chat, voice-note transcription, USSD (move to v1.5 unless Phase 0 shows many feature-phone vendors), languages beyond EN/SN/ND, AI photo-to-listing.

Resolved contradiction: v1 had vendor ratings in the feature list but "seller ratings" out of scope. Decision: internal vendor reliability score (prep time, cancellations, sold-while-held) is in v1 and used for ranking and penalties; **public** reviews are out until Phase 2.

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13. Roadmap with Gates

Phase 0: Validation (4–8 weeks, concierge)

- One cluster (e.g. one bhero market plus surrounding suburbs), 10–20 vendors, a few couriers.
- Run orders, visits and pickups over WhatsApp + spreadsheet, **in all three languages**, to learn which language each audience really prefers and which words work.
- **Go/no-go gates** (targets to be calibrated): visit show-up rate ≥ 60% (≥ 75% with deposit); reservation → purchase ≥ 35%; ≥ 70% of vendors respond to requests within 15 min; at least 50% of vendors say the bot is usable in their language without help.

Phase 1: MVP (pickup + reserve-to-view). As in section 12.

Phase 2: Delivery & trust. More delivery zones where unit economics work, multi-store batching, public reviews, condition disputes, USSD, meet-up points, translation of vendor-written text on demand (opt-in).

Phase 3: Growth. More markets and cities, additional Zimbabwean languages, promoted stands, referral program, bulk listing and photo-to-listing, voice listing, deposit-backed reservations at scale.

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14. Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Poor or stiff translations erode trust	Native-speaker translators + reviewers, glossary, in-app "report wording" link, user testing in both cities

Risk	Mitigation
Dialect differences (Shona dialects, Ndebele regional use)	Plain, widely understood register; test with varied reviewers; keep copy short
Translations break layouts	40% text-expansion tolerance; pseudo-localisation and screenshot tests
Code-switched search fails	Synonym map, log-driven improvements
Vendors misunderstand bot commands	Numbered menus first; keywords as a bonus; agent call-back
Cost of maintaining 3 languages	Controlled vocabulary, template system, translate in batches per release
Delivery unreliable or costly	Launch only in dense zones; pickup/visit first
Visit no-shows	Optional deposit, one-strike rule, buyer rating, vendor block
Vendor sells a held item	Hold rules, reliability score, deposit refund + apology credit
Ambiguous addresses	Landmark + pin + phone; courier escalation
Low digital literacy	Icon UI, WhatsApp/USSD, agent-assisted listing, voice notes
Cash handling and trust	Pickup codes, receipts, payout holds for new vendors
Cold start	Seed with agent-photographed stock before opening buyer side
Data costs	Light app, compressed images, WhatsApp over push where cheaper
Currency and price confusion (USD/ZiG)	Explicit currency labels; clear rounding; vendor chooses accepted currencies
Safety at meet-ups	Visits at known stands/markets by default; no home addresses shared; report/block tools

15. Open Questions with Recommended Defaults

Question	Recommendation
Courier separate app or mode?	Start as a **WhatsApp-driven pilot** for couriers; build a dedicated lightweight app only if pilot succeeds
Who manages inventory at launch?	**Agents for stands**; vendors self-manage shops once comfortable
Hold windows?	Cart 10 min; pickup 24 h; visit = slot + 15 min grace
Deposit default?	**Opt-in per vendor**, strongly suggested for high-value items; test in Phase 0
"Not as described" refund policy?	Inspect-first means most issues are caught at the stand; for in-app purchases without inspection, short return window with refund to wallet, vendor reliability impact
Individual sellers at launch?	**Shops and stands first**; individuals once verification flow is proven
Cash commission collection?	Net against prepaid sales; weekly invoice as fallback
Launch cluster/city?	Decide with data; **Harare (Mupedzanhamo/Mbare area) is the likely densest cluster**, but test Bulawayo early to validate Ndebele experience
Delivery in v1?	**Pilot only** in one zone
Languages at launch?	**EN, SN, ND for all core flows**, no phased rollout of a single language
Machine translation of user content?	Not in v1; consider opt-in "translate this listing" later

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16. Success Metrics (with draft targets)

- Visit show-up rate: ≥ 70% (with deposit ≥ 80%)
- Reservation → purchase: ≥ 40%

- Order completion rate: ⩾ 85%
- Vendor cancellation (couldn't fulfil): ⩽ 5%
- Vendor response time: median ⩽ 10 min
- 30-day repeat purchase: ⩾ 25%
- Time from agent onboarding to first live listing: ⩽ 48 h
- Pickup vs delivery vs visit split (monitor)
- **Language metrics (new):** share of users by language; % of sessions where language is switched within first 3 sessions (high = wrong default); support tickets mentioning wording/confusion; bot "not understood" rate by language (target < 10%); drop-off by language at each funnel step to expose weak translations
- Active listings per vendor per week; vendor retention
- AOV and fee coverage per order

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17. Brand & Name

- Working name: **Thriftly**. Check the name's pronounceability and meaning in Shona and Ndebele; many speakers will say it differently, so test early.
- Alternatives: Bhero, Rethread, Local Vintage, Finders. A Shona or Ndebele tagline could sit beside the English one (e.g. a short line about finding and checking clothes at the stand), written and vetted by native speakers.
- Voice: fast, playful, warm, respectful in all three languages. Avoid slang that excludes older vendors.
- Locally rooted copy: "reserve to view", "collect at the stand", "find the stall", each with a natural SN and ND equivalent chosen by testing.

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18. Sections still to add

Legal and compliance (data protection, consumer protection, tax, mobile-money regulation, second-hand goods rules), support playbook, vendor onboarding playbook (including a script in each language), marketing and launch plan, hiring (agents, translators, support), courier partnerships, and a translation operations runbook.